



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Hudson Valley Classical Academy
School Website: <http://hudsonvalleychristian.org>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Hudson Valley Classical Academy (HVCA) presents a distinctly Christian orientation, with explicit statements that academics are "Academics That Honor God and Recognize Him as The Creator and Sustainer of All Things," biblically based values, and liturgical/community activities such as Spiritual Emphasis Week and Spirit Week. Public-facing materials emphasise character formation, virtue, and religious formation (e.g., a Statement of Faith, God-centered language, and weekly spiritual activities). However, explicit classical elements commonly associated with a formal "Great Books" program, the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Conversation, and a fully articulated liberal-arts curriculum are not prominently evidenced in HVCA's public materials. The school also demonstrates substantial family involvement in governance and community life (parent interviews, parental participation in school activities), which aligns with classical education's emphasis on parental partnership but is not a universal hallmark of all classical schools. Overall, HVCA exhibits clear classical-influenced alignment in religious and community dimensions, but with less explicit signaling in core curriculum and pedagogy conventions that define a fully classical model in the six-category rubric. Therefore, the aggregate assessment places HVCA as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

- The strongest classical signals: Religious/metaphysical foundations and liturgical/community practices; strong parental involvement and partnership statements; formation-focused language (virtue, character, God's truth) evident in teacher and admissions materials. See evidence drawn from HVCA public content (e.g., About HVCA page, Statement of Faith, Spiritual Emphasis Week, and admissions materials) and the corresponding knowledge-base rubric.
- What would move HVCA toward a fully classical rating: explicit, public articulation of liberal-arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium) and Great Books/Great Conversation; explicit signaling of contemplative scholastic-based pedagogy; a stated model for the faculty as living curriculum; deeper, formalized model of parent partnerships as co-educators in everyday practice; and explicit Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - HVCA explicitly frames academics as honoring God and recognizing Him as Creator and Sustainer. This is reinforced by biblically-based values (self-control, care for others, respect for authority) woven into daily life. - The public materials reference a Statement of Faith and affiliation with Christian/ACI networks, signaling theology as a governing lens. - Liturgical/communal practices are evident via recurring events like Spiritual Emphasis Week, Spirit Week, International Week, etc.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: God, Creator, Sustainer, theology, Statement of Faith, biblically-based values, spiritual emphasis, worship-like communal activities. These align

with Positive Keywords in the classical rubric (theology, sacred order, liturgical practice). - Negative keywords: None evident around theological secularization or absence of religious grounding; no direct “Lack of Theology” signals found in HVCA materials. (No explicit negatives found in the sources reviewed.)

Why this rating - HVCA strongly foregrounds God-centered, theological formation and liturgical/community life, which are core markers in the Classical School rubric for religious/metaphysical foundations. The alignment is robust, though the explicit signaling of other classical pillars (e.g., Great Books or Trivium-based curriculum) is not evident in the materials reviewed. This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than fully CLASSICAL, due to the current lack of explicit Great Books and classical curriculum signaling in public materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation and virtue through biblically-based values (self-control, care for others, respect for authority) and God-centered aims. This points to formation of character and virtue as a central goal. - References to God’s truth (e.g., Second Grade teacher statements describing infusing God’s truth) indicate engagement with transcendental, knowable truths. - The presence of a Statement of Faith and the integration of theology into daily practice signal a formation-focused purpose rather than purely vocational preparation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, virtue, character, wisdom (implied through formation language), God’s truth, sacred/holy, formation, moral/yet transcendent aims, virtue-based language. The Positive Keywords list in the classical rubric includes “truth, goodness, beauty,” “virtue,” and “formation.” HVCA content demonstrates truth-oriented language (God’s truth) and formation-oriented aims. - Negative keywords detected: There is limited explicit signaling around “formation vs. information” in HVCA’s public materials; while formation is implied, explicit statements that education is “formation, not information” in the classical sense are not overtly present in HVCA’s public content. This yields a modest presence of negative signals if one requires explicit phrasing beyond formation language.

Why this rating - HVCA demonstrates formation/virtue-oriented aims and transcendental truth signals, which aligns with the essential elements of classical education. However, the public materials do not consistently articulate the classic triad of formation as the primary aim over information in a crisp, explicit way. This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 2.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public HVCA materials emphasize a biblically-based, standardized curriculum and Christian ethos rather than a liberal-arts curriculum explicitly centered on the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium) or Great Books. The materials show a standard curriculum with Christian framing rather than explicit liberal-arts sequencing. - There is no explicit public signaling of Great Books, Great Conversation, or a formal Trivium/Quadrivium framework in HVCA content. References to “Statement of Faith” and standardizing curriculum dominate rather than the classic liberal-arts framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Essential Elements’ curriculum signaling include Great Books, Great Conversation, Trivium, Quadrivium, wonder, grammar/logic/rhetoric. HVCA public content does not show these terms; thus 0 positive curriculum keywords match. - Negative keywords signals: Not explicitly signaling a lack of a classical curriculum, but the absence of classical curriculum signals (and explicit Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium language) is the dominant pattern. From the knowledge-base negative keyword lists, signals like “Lack of Culture Transmission” or “Lack of Partnership with Families” are not the primary focus for HVCA’s curriculum; the absence of classical signals is the relevant negative signal here.

Why this rating - The absence of explicit classical curriculum components (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation) in HVCA’s public materials supports NOT CLASSICAL for Element 3.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - HVCA public materials emphasize religious formation and daily virtue; there is no explicit articulation of Socratic seminars, classical dialogs, or deliberate rhetoric training, nor the lower-to-upper division pedagogy that typifies classical pedagogy. The content leans toward faith-based instruction and character formation rather than visible classical-methodology signals. - The presence of liturgical/community practices and emphasis on “formation” are not, in themselves, a robust signal of standardized classical pedagogy (e.g., contemplative/restful pedagogy, Insel-Solé style, or systematic Socratic instruction). The materials do not clearly describe a routine of Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates in upper grades.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Essential Elements’ pedagogy include Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric, scholé, contemplation, and disciplined memory work. HVCA materials do not present these pedagogy signals; 0 explicit matches. - Negative keywords: The explicit absence of classical pedagogy signals (Socratic methods, seminars, debates, rhetoric-based presentations) suggests a NOT CLASSICAL signal in pedagogy.

Why this rating - Without explicit evidence of classical pedagogical methods (Socratic dialogue, rhetoric training, disciplined rhetoric practice in upper grades), Element 4 aligns with NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - HVCA public materials center on the school’s religious identity and student formation rather than a clearly articulated “living curriculum” or a defined teacher-mentor culture. Individual teacher pages or testimonials are present, but there is no explicit “faculty as living curriculum,” “model teachers,” or a formal teacher-profile framework described at scale. - Some teacher descriptions (e.g., a Second Grade teacher’s bio) exist, but there is no widely shared statement about the faculty embodying virtues or forming a “core of the school” beyond general spiritual formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Essential Elements’ faculty signals (model teachers, living curriculum, collegial, portrait of teacher/student) are not explicitly demonstrated in HVCA’s public-facing content. The absence of explicit faculty-as-core signaling yields 0 positive matches for the classical faculty signals. - Negative keywords: There is no explicit negative signaling about faculty; the absence is the main signal for NOT CLASSICAL in this category.

Why this rating - The absence of explicit, public signals that the faculty serves as the living curriculum or as model-virtue mentors in HVCA’s materials supports a NOT CLASSICAL rating for Element 5.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HVCA materials show active parental engagement in school life through admissions processes (parent interviews with School Board; parental involvement in governance) and parental participation in school activities (board members, volunteers, and administrative involvement). This aligns with classical education’s emphasis on parental partnership. - The school’s materials also indicate a broader community focus: involvement in spiritual programs and community events, as well as connections to faith-based networks (Association of Christian Schools International). - The presence of a “Statement of Faith” and religious formation elements often pairs with classical education’s emphasis on formation in virtue and shared inquiries with parents as co-educators in the family-school partnership model. The ICE pamphlet and related classical-education literature in the knowledge base also describe parents as co-teachers and participants in formation (though not all HVCA pages spell this out in the same language, the admissions and governance structure signals significant parental involvement).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, parent involvement, board membership, parental presence in school governance, family engagement, and shared formation. These align with Positive Keywords in the “Parents & Community” category. - Negative keywords: None evident in HVCA’s public materials; the HVCA materials emphasize parental involvement rather than parental exclusion or “lack of partnership.”

Why this rating - The public-facing materials show substantial parental involvement and family partnership signals, matching a Classical emphasis for category 6. The evidence supports CLASSICAL for Element 6.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, HVCA displays strong religious/metaphysical and parental-partnership signals characteristic of classical education, but it lacks explicit, public signals for core classical curriculum (Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium) and classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, intellectual union of disciplines). With the balance of evidence, the school is best characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum signaling
- Publicly articulate a liberal-arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Trivium; Quadrivium) and clearly tie it to Great Books and the Great Conversation in the curriculum pages.
- Present explicit examples of Great Books or canonical western texts used in grades K–12 and demonstrate how interdisciplinary connections are cultivated (history, literature, philosophy, sciences) within a unified classical context.
- Pedagogy signaling
- Explicitly describe classroom practices aligned with classical pedagogy (Socratic discussions in upper grades; seminars/debates; student rhetoric exercises; opportunities for public speaking and oration).
- Include examples of contemplative, restful moments in the curriculum (scholé-inspired approach) and how memory work and recitation contribute to learning.
- Faculty signaling
- Publicly articulate a “living curriculum” model and a teacher-mentors framework, including professional development focused on modeling virtue and classical pedagogical practices.
- Highlight profiles of faculty values, mentorship roles, and collaboration that align with classical ideals.
- Parent/community signaling
- Strengthen public messaging about parents as co-educators in practice (not only governance) through examples of parent-led study groups, shared reading lists, or joint family learning activities.
- Religious/metaphysical signaling (to deepen CLASSICAL alignment)
- Maintain and expand liturgical and communal practices, explicitly connecting them to a broader classical framework (e.g., why liturgical practices support the formation of wisdom and virtue as part of the Great Conversation).
- Additional clarity on formation vs. information
- Explicitly state how HVCA balances formation (virtue, character, God-centered ends) with information (academic rigor) and show how classical formation integrates with academic content.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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